

Stranger to LOVE

Two women struggle to come to terms with marriage and adultery in Kolkata

By Damayanti Datta



ILLICIT
by DIBYENDU PALIT
Translated by
ARUNAVA SINHA
Penguin
Price: Rs 150
Pages: 122



THERE WAS NO ONE AT THE BUS STOP
by SIRSHENDU MUKHOPADHYAY
Translated by
ARUNAVA SINHA
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Two women, portrayed by two writers. Both belong to the same city and milieu, upper middle-class Kolkata. Both have nearly everything—well-off husbands, well-appointed homes, lives of leisure. Yet through cracks in the comfortable monotony of their lives, loneliness seeps in, time hangs heavy. As they struggle to play out their roles, the craving for something new starts. The jagged edges of that craving begin to soften as they find love, or some version of it, with strangers who enter their lives.

Forty-three years after Buddhadeva Bose's novel, *It Rained all Night*, opened with a woman's frank assertion, "I did it", adultery is hardly a novel word in the world of Bangla literature. But Dibyendu Palit's *Illicit* (*Oboidha*, 1989) and Sirshendu Mukhopadhyay's *There Was No One at the Bus Stop* (*Bus Stope Keu Nei*, 1974) are different in tone and flavour. They don't tell both sides of the story. The only mindscape you get acquainted to is the woman's. The "wronged" husbands are almost invisible and the "other" men appear as a clutch for the story-line. It's the woman who tells her story, tosses out her arguments, critiques her life, clamours for individuality, asserts her sexuality, and generally knocks down her own moral compass by stepping into the morass of modernity.

In *Illicit*, tears of satiation come to Jeena Banerjee's eyes as she lies with her new lover during a clandestine trip to Puri, although she feels cheapened by his brand of physicality, swinging between intimacy and

violence with ease. In *There Was No One at the Bus Stop*, Trina finds it difficult to tell love from sin. When she thinks of her lover, she feels uncomfortable to look at her husband or her children. "She looked around furtively without reason. She even feared her own shadow."

What separates Jeena and Trina is not just a decade, but a mindset, too. Trina's perpetual guilt over her illicit relationship, lack of self-esteem and tendency to swallow insults from her dysfunctional family are totally absent in Jeena, the well-educated '90s girl. She gets angry with herself—be it for succumbing to nine years of unexciting marriage or her reckless love-trip with a man she's attracted to. Both women propel the doom of their marriage. While Trina seems unable to let go of her old ties, Jeena's story ends with the possibility that the damage to her marriage, as well as love life, is irreparable. She is not sorry for committing adultery. She has no sense of guilt. But she is ready to walk it alone.

Translator Arunava Sinha is doing a commendable job of translating contemporary Bangla classics. Literature and translation have

a long-term relationship that needs to be nurtured, especially in an increasingly homogenised India where the risk of passing over regional voices looms large. Yet, the two translated works generate a frisson of anxiety: Palit and Mukhopadhyay are very different story-tellers, with their own unique styles, metaphors, and figures of speech. The translations have rubbed away those hallmark identities—as if written by the same pen. Yes, a translation is supposed to be a new work, but in this case, slightly unsettling for those who have read the original.



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